

In



September, hundreds showed up at The Nines, a spacious restaurant in Mumbai, to find out which one of the Fisher brothers Isabel Conklin aka Belly would pick to be her bae. The trio, projected in all their bronzy glitz above the seated viewers, are the leads of *The Summer I Turned Pretty* (*TSITP*), a show about school crushes, love triangles, heartbreaks, yearning and other experiences that apparently make teenagers swoon helplessly. And so it was that its 75-minute season finale was screened with all the pomp and aplomb its dedicated fan base deserved. The Nines was dressed to the nines—mirroring the beachside setting of the show, while a DIY charm bracelet stall was set up to echo the one given to Belly by a loving mother figure. The centrepiece was a two-tier dark chocolate cake with a raspberry coulis filling and glossy mirror glaze made from 70 per cent cacao—to reflect the precise wedding cake that the younger Fisher brother, Jeremiah, wanted for himself. Some viewers hoped that Belly would choose him (team Jeremiah/ #Jellyfishers) and others that she'd go for the elder one, Conrad (team Conrad/ #Bonrad). Gasps, cheers, awws and screams filled The Nines through the episode and viewers walked away reassured that they need not say goodbye just yet—the characters will return in a newly announced movie.

TSITP is not the only young adult (YA) show generating waves. The genre, showcasing youngsters and their coming-of-age hopes and obstacles, has seen a surge in popularity as a whole, and studios are jumping on the bandwagon. The success of films like *Saiyaara*—about two awkward youngsters trying to make their relationship work—and the *Culpa* trilogy—a Spanish drama about stepsiblings-turned-lovers—has helped. So have shows like *Maxton Hall* (an interclass romance set in an elite German school), *Wednesday* (a horror comedy about a young psychic), *Heartstopper* (a classic romance between two teen boys) and *Kota Factory* (about young IIT aspirants). Netflix has announced new seasons of *Mismatched* (a romantic drama set in Jaipur) and *Class* (a crime thriller focused on student life in a posh school). Amazon Prime has greenlit season two of the Ananya Panday-led *Call Me Bae* (about a rich girl who falls from grace) and is developing two more shows to woo the youth, including *Lukkha*, featuring rapper and songwriter King (of 'Tu Maan Meri Jaan' fame) and a musical by Ankur Tiwari.

A TEMPTING SLATE
1: The Summer I Turned Pretty
2: Call Me Bae **3:** Mismatched
4: Kota Factory



WHY YA WORKS

If there's one defining feature that makes the genre addictive, it's the emphasis on idyllic, often saccharine, romances with a central couple to rally behind. *Mismatched*, with a successful run of three seasons and another on its way, taps into this formula. "It has been one of those rare shows that